

For reasons I cannot quite articulate, shows I consumed before 2023 now feel laborious to revisit, even though my affection for their characters remains intact. It is as though the part of my heart reserved for fictional people has reached capacity. I can admire new stories, recognize their craft, even enjoy them in the moment—but the attachment feels thinner, more conditional.

Take *Bridgerton*, for instance. While audiences seem enamored with the newest pairing—some even ranking them just below Queen Charlotte and her king—I find myself stalled at season two. I see the appeal. I understand the writing choices. Yet I cannot sink into it. The characters do not linger with me. They do not follow me into idle thoughts or quiet evenings the way earlier ones did.



Not Everyone Wants To Be Blair Waldorf



I think of Serena and Blair, of the entire Upper East Side, really—how they have occupied my interior world for seven years. And Countless others. I met them in my teens, and perhaps that is the key.

Adolescence is porous. You are still assembling yourself. Fiction does not merely entertain you then; it instructs you, consoles you, offers templates for desire and defiance and selfhood. You do not just watch characters—you try them on. You borrow their confidence, their wit, almost their entire personality

At nineteen—still technically a teenager, but no longer new to longing—I find that nothing quite embeds itself the same way. Perhaps attachment requires a certain openness that dulls with familiarity.

Adulthood fragments attention too. Responsibilities intrude. Fiction must compete with everyday life. It no longer fills the whole horizon; it occupies a corner.

And then there is nostalgia—the most ruthless editor of all. The characters you loved first are entangled with who you were when you loved them. Revisiting them is not just revisiting a story; it is revisiting a former self. New characters cannot compete with that intimacy because they lack the temporal depth. They have not grown with you.

So the larger question emerges: Have I run out of love? Or have I simply become more discerning with it? Why does my favorite refuge sometimes feel like a prison—episodes playing in the background while my mind drifts elsewhere?

The less faith I have in media, the more tempted I am to consume it passively—if nothing feels precious, I might as well choose what demands the least of me. But that is not indifference; it is fatigue. When stories stop feeling sacred, they begin to feel transactional.

There are still shows that slip past the defenses. They remind me that attachment is not impossible—just rarer. Perhaps we do not outgrow loving fictional characters. Perhaps we simply require more from them. More authenticity. More risk. More reflection of who we are becoming, not just who we once were.

Maybe the heart does not fill up. Maybe it becomes selective.